4 Rajaji Marg was our home for more than two-and-a-half years. The official residence of the chief of army staff was a well-appointed bungalow. Moving into this house was a special event. Rohini had done up the interiors very elegantly and that gave the house warmth and good vibes. We had the privilege of hosting many important visitors, intellectuals and foreign dignitaries, including army chiefs of many countries. The Army Day reception and the garden party for ladies of the station were well-attended annual events.

Our last morning in the house was truly memorable. The home looked empty as the baggage had already been moved to our new abode in the cantonment. After our morning tea had been served, it occurred to me that we would have nothing to do after midday, once the formalities of handing over the command of the Indian Army to my successor had been completed. Having led such a hectic life for over four decades in uniform, here was something that I was certainly not used to! However, for a change, we decided to relax and spend a quiet day together. Nostalgia flooded our emotions and we wished to savour the warmth and memories of what had been our beautiful home for the past two years and eight months, reliving the happy memories of our stay. On this, our last day amidst these lovely surroundings, we wanted to soak in as much as possible of the gracious colonial bungalow so reminiscent of the 'Raj', with its colonnaded portico and verandahs, its impeccably manicured lawns and garden, complete with a waterfall and lush verdant surroundings. We walked around the house at peace with ourselves, which was a most tranquil and soothing experience. We spoke to our children and the rest of the family, recounting the events and activities of the past few extremely busy days. They were proud of our achievements and appeared content that we would now have more time for them. Life had been full of surprises and 30 September 2009 was no exception. Around midday I went through the formal ritual of handing over charge to my successor. That done, it was a very satisfied 'chief' accompanied by the 'first lady' of the army, together with the military assistant and other personal staff, who walked briskly along the corridor and then downstairs to the